

Shopping Lists

Turning messy shopping intent into intelligent baskets

Role

Senior Product Designer

Company

Waitrose & Partners

Timeline

12 weeks

Focus

AI-assisted commerce / Behavioural UX / Systems design

Overview

Customers don't naturally think in products.

They think in:

- meals
- routines
- reminders
- brands
- household habits
- vague notes like "milk" or "bread"

At Waitrose, shopping lists were one of the strongest behavioural signals linked to larger basket sizes and repeat purchasing. But existing list experiences still relied heavily on manual product searching and repetitive basket building.

I led the design of an AI-assisted shopping list experience that transformed messy real-world shopping intent into intelligent, editable baskets.

The goal wasn't full automation.

It was to reduce effort while keeping customers fully in control.

Why this mattered

Shopping lists sat at the centre of weekly grocery planning.

Research showed:

- Customers using lists spent significantly more than those who didn't
- 65%+ of customers still created physical lists
- 56% used hybrid planning behaviour combining meals and individual items
- New online grocery customers often started with incomplete or ambiguous intent

This created a major opportunity:

How could we help customers move from intention to basket faster — without removing confidence or control?

The problem

Real-world shopping behaviour is messy.

Customers rarely think in exact product titles or SKUs.

Instead, they create fragmented reminders throughout the week:

- handwritten notes
- screenshots
- meals
- family requests
- generic reminders
- brand references

Traditional grocery experiences forced customers to manually translate these into products one item at a time.

This created:

- slow basket building
- decision fatigue
- repetitive searching
- low confidence
- friction for new customers switching from competitors

The challenge was not simply list creation.

It was intelligently interpreting intent.

Behavioural insights

Customers planned before they shopped

Planning often happened away from the supermarket.

Lists were created across multiple moments throughout the week using:

- notes apps
- paper lists
- conversations
- screenshots
- meal inspiration

The shopping experience needed to support natural planning behaviour rather than forcing customers into structured grocery logic.

Intent was highly ambiguous

Simple inputs like:

- “milk”
- “bread”
- “pasta”

required interpretation.

Customers expected the system to understand context, preferences and likely behaviour.

The problem wasn't product matching.

It was confidence-based recommendation.

Automation only worked when customers stayed in control

Testing showed customers became uncomfortable when products were added too aggressively or felt irreversible.

Confidence increased significantly when:

- recommendations were editable
- alternatives were visible
- quantities could be changed easily
- meals could be expanded or removed
- customers understood why suggestions appeared

This became a core design principle throughout the experience.

Hypothesis

We believed that if we could:

- capture shopping intent naturally
- intelligently interpret ambiguous inputs
- generate editable draft baskets
- and keep refinement lightweight

...we could reduce planning effort while increasing customer confidence, basket completion and repeat usage.

Design principles

Reduce effort — not control

AI should accelerate basket building without removing customer ownership.

Start with intent, not products

Customers think in meals and household needs, not exact product names.

Keep refinement lightweight

Editing quantities, swapping products and removing items needed to feel effortless.

Make the system feel collaborative

The experience should feel assistive rather than automated.

The solution

I designed an AI-assisted shopping workflow that transformed lists, meals and mixed-input planning into intelligent draft baskets.

The system combined:

- behavioural signals
- popularity data
- customer history
- lightweight preferences

- OCR-assisted capture
- recommendation confidence logic

...to generate personalised product suggestions in seconds.

Rather than presenting a rigid shopping flow, the experience adapted to how customers already planned their weekly shops.

Capture shopping intent naturally

Customers could:

- type freeform lists
- paste copied notes
- upload handwritten lists
- combine meals with individual items
- create messy, real-world inputs

The experience intentionally supported imperfect behaviour.

This reduced the cognitive effort required before customers even started shopping.

Generate intelligent draft baskets

The system translated vague intent into product recommendations using:

- popularity patterns
- behavioural signals
- favourites and purchase history
- lightweight preference data
- confidence scoring

High-confidence items could be pre-selected.

Ambiguous items surfaced editable alternatives.

Meals were grouped together to create clearer mental models around planning.

Keep customers in control

One of the most important product decisions was avoiding over-automation.

Customers could:

- swap products

- edit quantities
- remove meals
- deselect suggestions
- expand grouped recipes
- refine baskets continuously

The goal was to make the system feel collaborative rather than prescriptive.

Key product decisions

We intentionally avoided full automation

Testing showed customers lost trust when products appeared without transparency or easy editing.

Editable recommendations created significantly stronger confidence.

We prioritised mixed-input behaviour

Customers naturally combined:

- meals
- reminders
- household products
- generic items

Supporting hybrid behaviour became more valuable than enforcing structured list creation.

We used confidence-based recommendation logic

Not every input should behave the same way.

High-confidence recommendations could streamline basket creation.

Lower-confidence suggestions surfaced alternatives instead.

This reduced automation anxiety while maintaining speed.

We designed for new customers first

Existing customers benefited from:

- favourites
- purchase history
- behavioural data

New customers required lightweight onboarding and popularity-based suggestions to avoid cold-start friction.

Validation & iteration

The prototype was tested with users across different shopping behaviours and planning habits.

Key learnings shaped several interaction decisions.

Customers expected flexibility

Many participants initially treated the experience as a planning space rather than a fixed shopping flow.

This led to:

- lighter interaction patterns
 - easier editing
 - expandable meal groups
 - simplified removal behaviours
-

Visibility improved trust

Customers became more confident when they could:

- understand recommendations
- review generated items
- easily refine outputs

Transparency became more important than aggressive automation.

Grouping improved comprehension

Users responded positively when meal-based products were grouped together.

This created stronger planning mental models and reduced visual fragmentation.

Impact

Reduced planning effort

The experience simplified the transition from intention to basket by reducing repetitive manual searching.

Increased confidence through editable AI

Customers trusted recommendations more when they remained flexible and transparent.

Created a scalable behavioural commerce framework

The project established foundations for future AI-assisted grocery experiences built around:

- intent interpretation
 - behavioural prediction
 - personalised recommendations
 - adaptive basket generation
-

Supported strategic growth opportunities

Shopping lists were strongly linked to higher-value customer behaviour and repeat purchasing.

The experience positioned Waitrose to explore more intelligent and personalised commerce journeys.

Reflection

This project reframed the problem from:

“How do customers create shopping lists?”

to:

“How do we intelligently transform intent into a shop?”

The most important learning was that automation alone does not create trust.

Customers valued speed — but only when they retained visibility, flexibility and control.

Designing for AI-assisted commerce meant balancing:

- intelligence with transparency
- automation with confidence
- speed with human behaviour

The result was a more adaptive and collaborative shopping experience designed around how people actually plan their lives.

Core skills demonstrated

- Product strategy
- Behavioural UX
- AI-assisted product design
- Systems thinking
- Information architecture
- Recommendation systems
- E-commerce optimisation
- Interaction design
- Rapid prototyping
- User research
- Cross-functional collaboration
- Data-informed design
- Design systems thinking